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Position Paper: The Bioethics of Autonomy and the Sanctity of Human Life

I. Introduction

Bioethics serves as the intersection between medical possibility and moral responsibility. As technology advances, humanity faces increasingly complex dilemmas regarding the control we exercise over life and death. This paper examines the morality of two significant bioethical issues: **Euthanasia** and **Contraception**. While modern secular ethics often prioritizes individual autonomy, a holistic moral framework—rooted in the dignity of the human person—suggests that our choices must always respect the intrinsic value of life from conception to natural death.

II. Position on Euthanasia: The Ethics of Natural Death

Euthanasia, or "mercy killing," is often presented as a solution to unbearable suffering. However, from a moral standpoint, the intentional ending of a human life—even with consent—undermines the foundational medical principle of "*Non-maleficence*" (Do No Harm).

- **The Argument against Euthanasia:** Human life possesses an inherent dignity that is not dependent on one's physical productivity or absence of pain. By legalizing euthanasia, society risks creating a "duty to die," where the elderly or ill feel pressured to end their lives to avoid being a burden to their families.
- **The Ethical Alternative:** Instead of ending the life of the patient, bioethics should promote **Palliative Care**. True compassion involves "suffering with" the patient (compassion) and providing advanced pain management and psychological support, allowing for a natural death that respects the patient's journey without violating the sanctity of life.

III. Position on Contraception: The Integrity of the Procreative Act

The use of artificial contraception remains a debated issue in bioethics, centering on the purpose of human sexuality and the beginning of life.

- **The Moral Concern:** The use of artificial contraception can be viewed as a technical intervention that separates the two essential dimensions of the marital act: the unitive (love-sharing) and the procreative (life-giving). When these are artificially decoupled, it can lead to a "contraceptive mentality" where life is seen as an object to be managed rather than a gift to be welcomed.

- **The Ethical Perspective:** Respecting the natural biological rhythms of the body through **Natural Family Planning (NFP)** is a more ethically sound approach. Unlike artificial means, NFP requires mutual discipline and respect for the natural order of the body, fostering a deeper sense of global citizenship and environmental responsibility by avoiding synthetic hormonal interference in human biology.

IV. Synthesis and Conclusion

The common thread between euthanasia and contraception is the desire for absolute control over the "thresholds" of life. While individual freedom is a significant value, it should not supersede the objective moral truth that life is a gift, not a commodity. A truly ethical society is one that protects the vulnerable at the end of life and honors the natural processes of creating life at its beginning. By upholding these standards, we ensure that medical progress serves humanity rather than dominating it.